

Amazon Rainforest



THE VAST AMAZON JUNGLE is the largest area of tropical rainforest in the world. It covers about 2,702,700 sq miles (7,000,000 sq km)—an area 12 times the size of France. The rainforest is situated in the huge basin of the Amazon River, which flows 4,000 miles (6,450 km) across South America. The weather in the Amazon basin is hot and humid year round.

The Amazon rainforest is home to a greater variety of wildlife than anywhere else on Earth. Many animals live in the treetops, where there are plenty of leaves, flowers, and fruit to feed on. Some, such as the spider monkey, have grasping tails and long nails to help them swing through the branches. Rainforest birds have short, broad wings and can fly through the trees. On the forest floor, many animals find food with long noses and sharp claws. Today, animals are threatened as humans clear rainforest land to farm and mine.



Rhethor blue morpho
(*Morpho rhethor*)
Wingspan: up to 6.7 in (17 cm)

Reflecting wings

The male morpho butterfly is brilliantly colored because of the way the tiny scales on its wings reflect the light. As the butterfly moves its wings, the colors change. Many morphos have been collected for jewelry or decoration, and they are in danger of becoming extinct.



Red-billed toucan
(*Ramphastos tucanus*)
Length: up to 1 ft 10 in (58 cm)

Big bill

With its long, hollow bill, the red-billed toucan can reach fruit on twigs too thin to bear its weight. The jagged edges of the bill work like a saw to cut fruit, which the toucan tosses back into its throat. The bright colors help the bird recognize others of its kind.

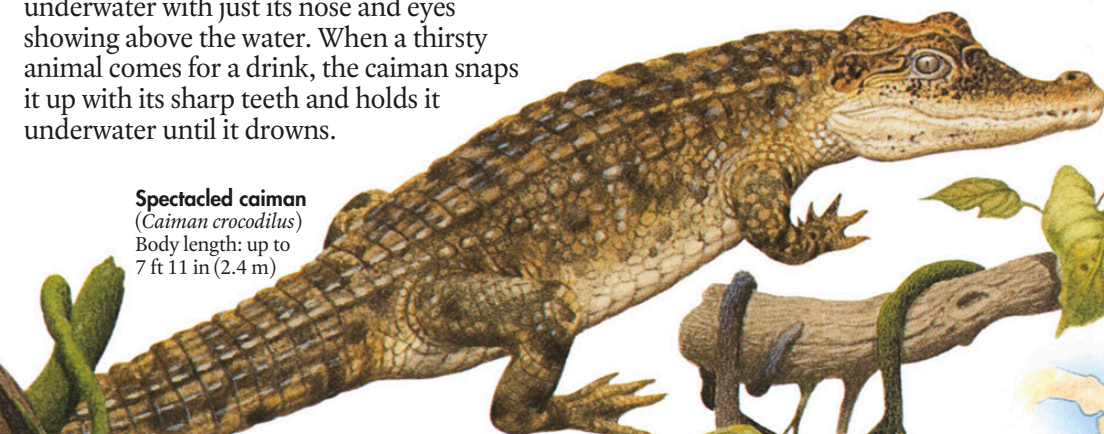
Underwater danger

The caiman is a type of crocodile. It lurks underwater with just its nose and eyes showing above the water. When a thirsty animal comes for a drink, the caiman snaps it up with its sharp teeth and holds it underwater until it drowns.



Hoatzin
(*Opisthocomus hoazin*)
Length: up to 2 ft 3 in (70 cm)

Spectacled caiman
(*Caiman crocodilus*)
Body length: up to 7 ft 11 in (2.4 m)



Acrobatic leaps

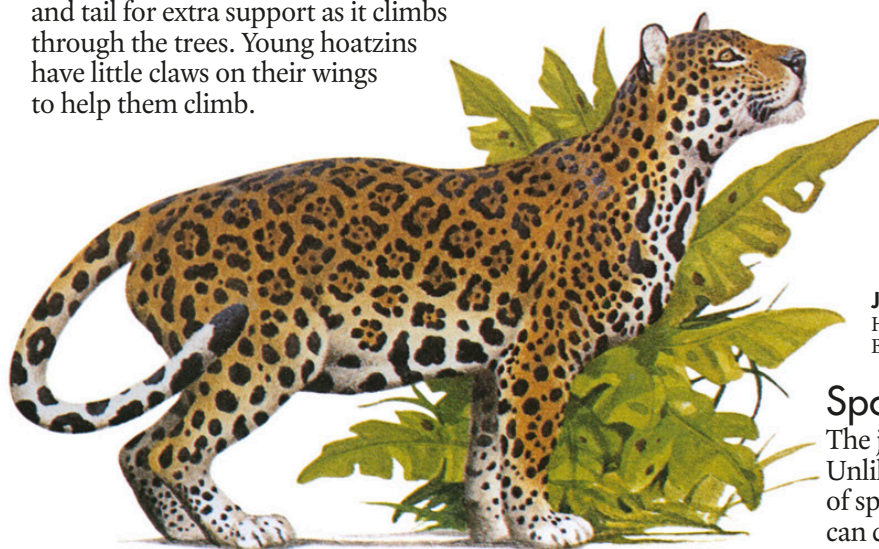
The spider monkey is an amazing acrobat. It makes leaps of 33 ft (10 m) or more through the trees, using its tail like a hand or foot. This type of tail is called prehensile. Underneath its tail is a patch of ridged skin, which helps it get a firm grip on the branches.



Black spider monkey
(*Ateles chamek*)
Body length: up to 2 ft (60 cm)
Tail: up to 2 ft 10 in (88 cm)

Weak wings

The hoatzin has such weak flight muscles that it cannot fly more than 330 ft (100 m) or so before it has to crash-land for a rest. It uses its wings and tail for extra support as it climbs through the trees. Young hoatzins have little claws on their wings to help them climb.



Jaguar (*Panthera onca*)
Height to shoulder: up to 2 ft 7 in (80 cm)
Body length: up to 5 ft 9 in (1.7 m)

Spotted cat

The jaguar is the largest cat in South America. Unlike the leopard, it has black marks inside each ring of spots. Its coat acts as a camouflage in the forest, and it can creep up on the animals it hunts without being seen.

GULF OF PANAMA

CARIBBEAN
Lake Maracaibo



The highest parts of the rainforest receive 120 in (305 cm) of rain each year.

PACIFIC OCEAN

AMAZON

HAPPY EAGLE

BROWN-THROATED THREE-TOED SLOTH

SCARLET MACAW